Group Assignment 2 - Heuristic Evaluation

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Web Apps Reviewed: GitHub, Canva, Booking.com

Web App 1: [Github.com]

Heuristic Violation 4: Consistency and Standards - Creating a New Issue

When you are creating a new issue, immediately on selecting “new issue” you see some filtering based on text (Figure 1). However, when you actually create the issue, there are all sorts of different drop downs, selections, and ways to tag, label, or track the issue. This makes it hard to know how each element fits in the bigger picture or even remember what you are supposed to do each time because each element is its own feature, there is no consistency between features in creating a new issue. As you use the system more, it can become more intuitive, but it still lacks consistency across the entire process.

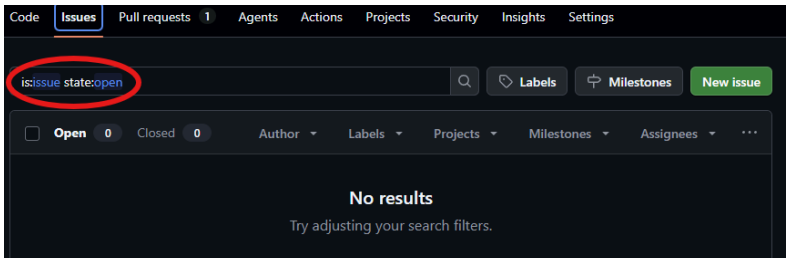


Figure 1. Text-based filters.

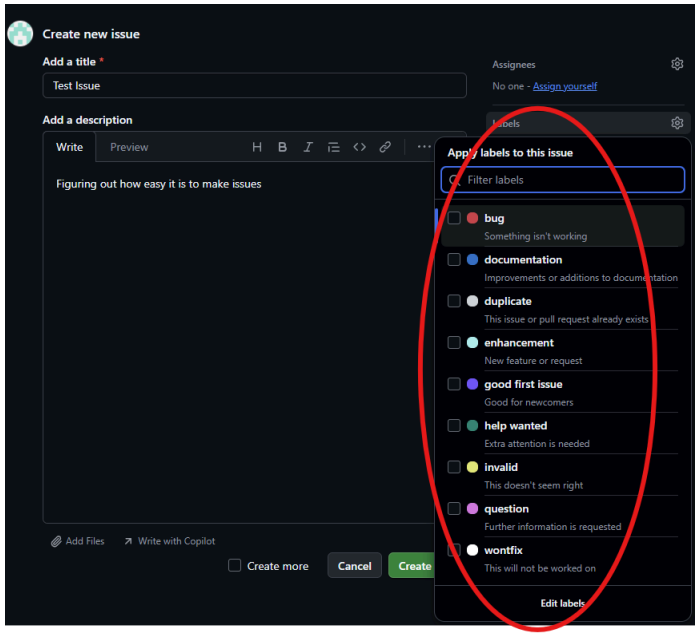


Figure 2. Selection-based filters.

Heuristic Violation 9: Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors / Violation 10: Help and Documentation - Reviewing a Pull Request

Another confusing feature is when you try to review a pull request that has a merge issue. Github will help point out that there are errors between the current branch and the pull request branch, but the syntax used to convey the differences between the two files does not fully help the user solve the error (Figure 3). There is not sufficient explanation for what accepting each change means or safeguards protecting from breaking the entire code base if the wrong change is accepted. There is also no easy way to go back and repair the error if a wrong change is accepted.

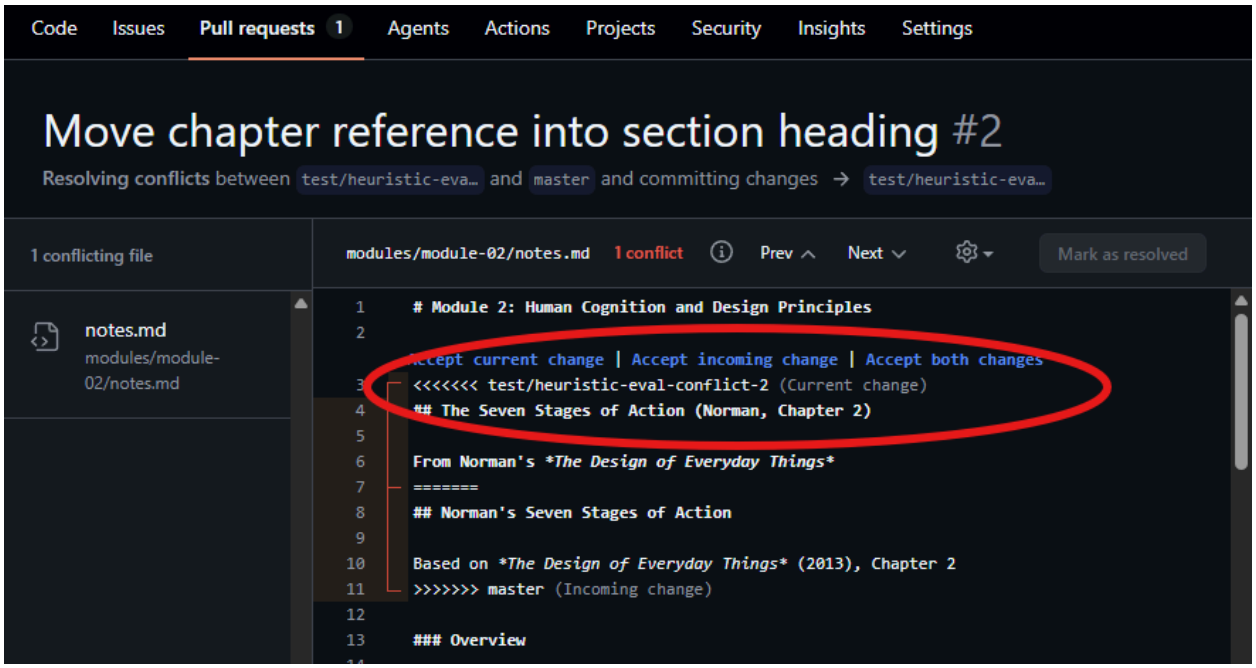


Figure 3. Confusing syntax when trying to showcasing errors.

Heuristic Violation 2: Match Between System and the Real World / Violation 6: Recognition Rather Than Recall - Exploring Project Settings

The settings page of GitHub repos is difficult to navigate. Some features are organized, others are in random spots, and the format of each is different. Furthermore, some pages are short, others, like the main page (Figure 4), have tons of tabs on the side but also have more features if you scroll down that you cannot find on the side. It does not provide side tab links to the features at the bottom of the page that you would be looking for. To edit settings you have to read web examples of how to set up the repo rather than being able to quickly use the GitHub web application directly. Furthermore, in actually trying to change the page visibility, the red button in the “Danger Zone” makes it appear as if there is supposed to be some other way to change the visibility. And on top of that, the pop-up when you do actually click the button (Figure 5) looks more like a tool-tip infographic than a change feature option. I would say because the

Github settings page is not intuitive, it fails the recognition heuristic principle forcing users to have to search or ask for help to accomplish tasks on the page.
Secondly, in all these (as well as other Github parts) it uses very technical jargon such as “pull request” and “fork” which do not always line up with what you would expect given the verbage. Github also exists on a command line interface field which means when it is translated into the web app, lots of times things do not line up between what you would expect from the real world and what is happening.

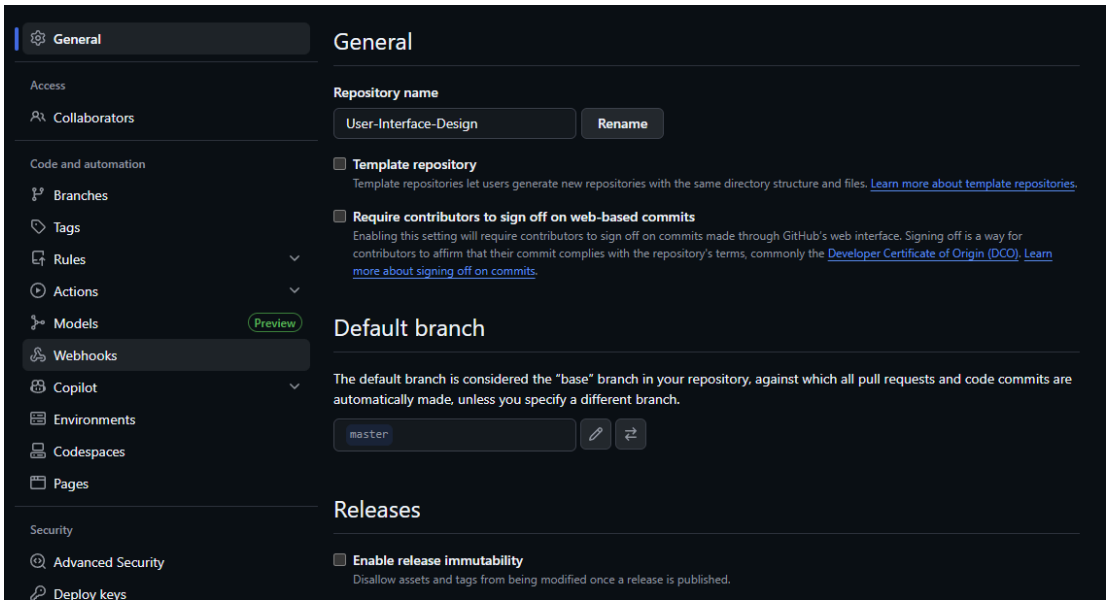


Figure 4. Complex settings page with little recognition abilities.

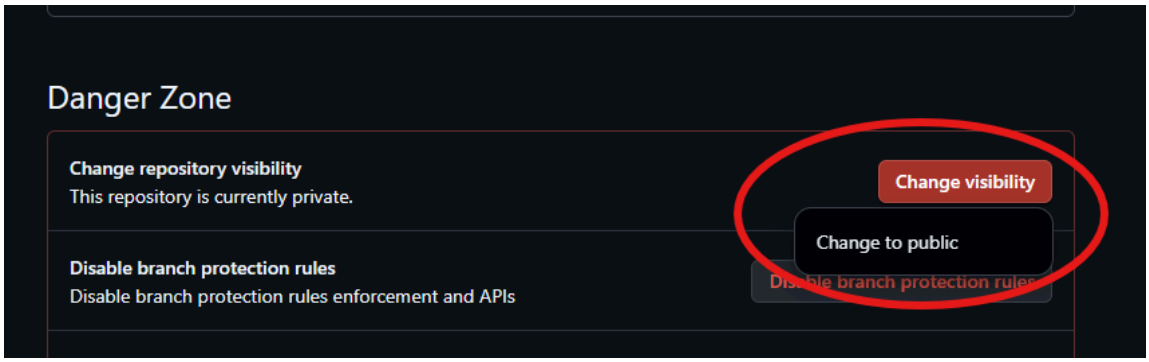


Figure 5. Settings page change visibility selection process.

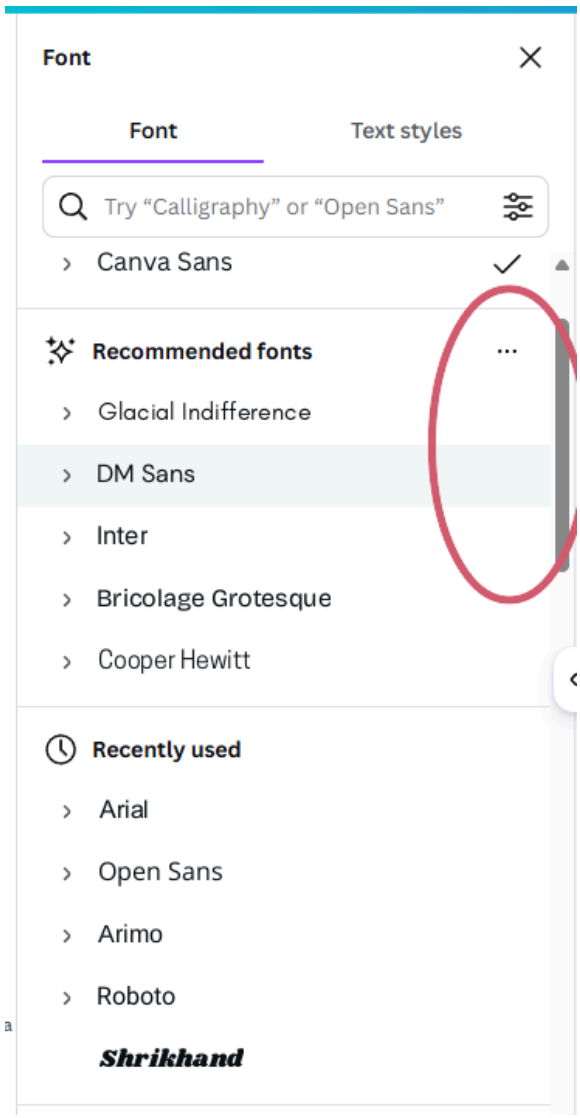
Web App 2: Canva

Issue 1: Font Selection Menu Overload

Violated Heuristic:
#6 – Recognition Rather Than Recall
#8 – Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Use Case: Basic Element Manipulation (Change font of text box)

Screenshot Evidence:



Description of Issue:
When changing the font of a text box, Canva presents a long, scrollable list of fonts that includes suggested fonts, brand fonts (if applicable), and numerous stylistic variations. The dropdown lacks strong visual grouping or filtering tools for quick narrowing beyond the search bar.

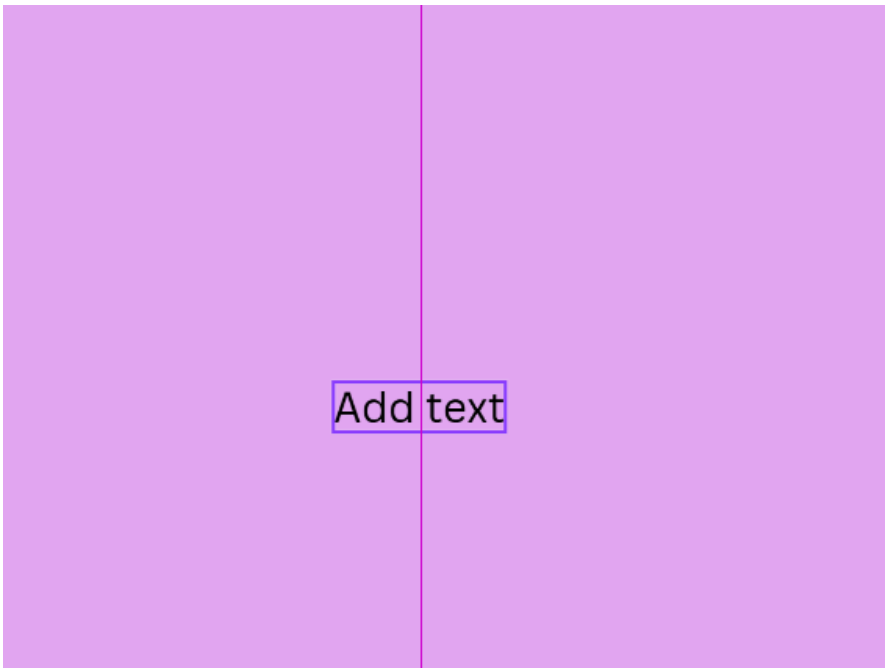
Explanation:
This violates Aesthetic and Minimalist Design because the interface presents a large volume of options simultaneously, increasing visual clutter and cognitive load. It also violates Recognition Rather Than Recall, as users may need to remember font names or manually search rather than relying on intuitive categorization (e.g., serif, sans-serif, modern, formal). The overwhelming list may slow decision-making and reduce efficiency.

Issue 2: Imprecise Center Alignment Feedback

Violated Heuristic:
#1 – Visibility of System Status

Use Case: Basic Element Manipulation (Align text precisely to center)

Screenshot:



Description:
When attempting to precisely center a text box, Canva provides temporary alignment guides (pink lines). However, these guides disappear immediately after placement and do not confirm exact positioning numerically or persistently.

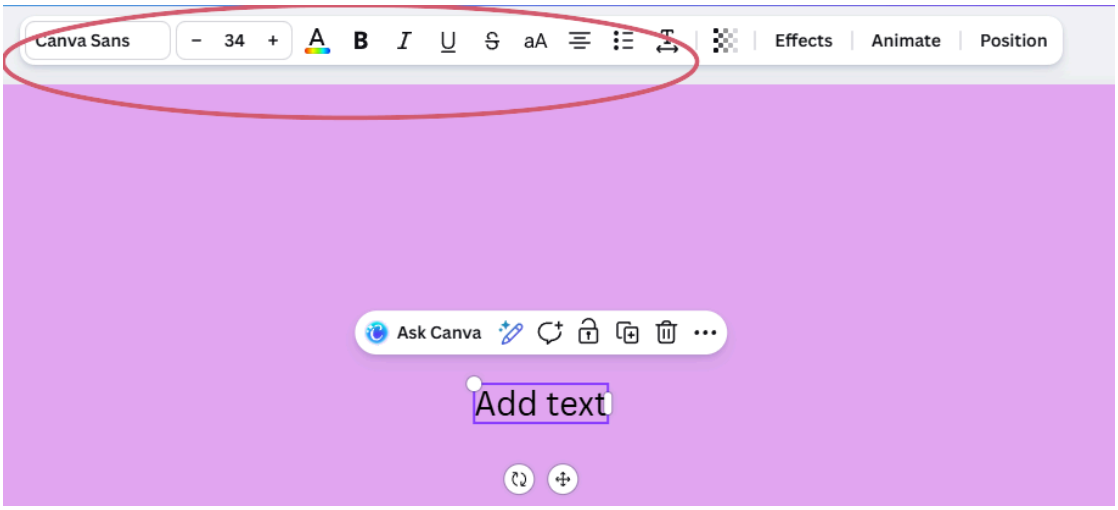
This violates Visibility of System Status because the system does not clearly communicate whether the object is perfectly centered after the user releases it. Without numeric position indicators or persistent confirmation, users lack feedback regarding the final alignment state.

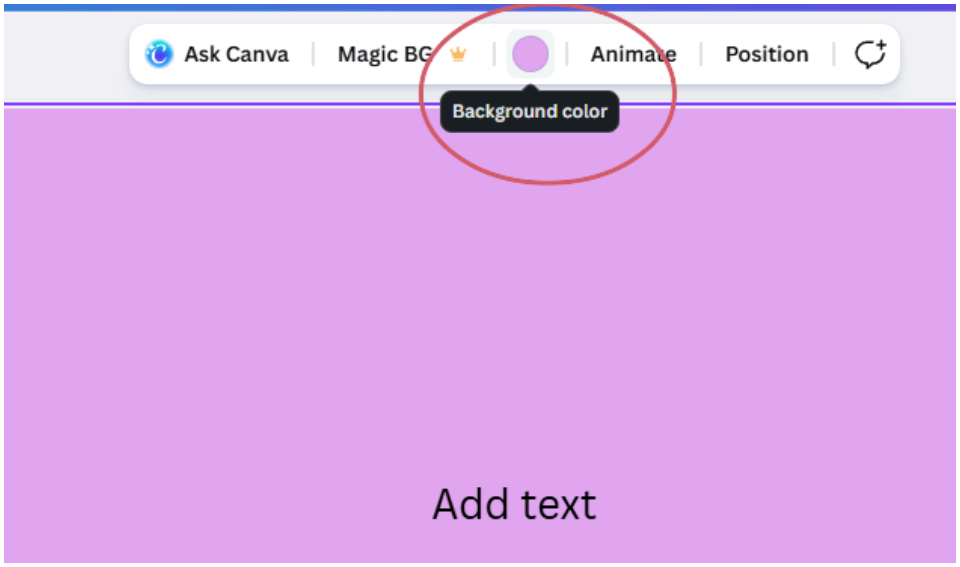
Issue 3: Background Color Change Is Not Immediately Discoverable

Violated Heuristic:
#1 – Visibility of System Status
#4 – Consistency and Standards

Use Case: Using the Undo History (Change background color as one of the edits)

Screenshot Evidence:





Description of Issue:
Changing the background color requires clicking on the canvas itself before the background color option appears in the top toolbar. If the canvas is not actively selected, the color option is hidden.

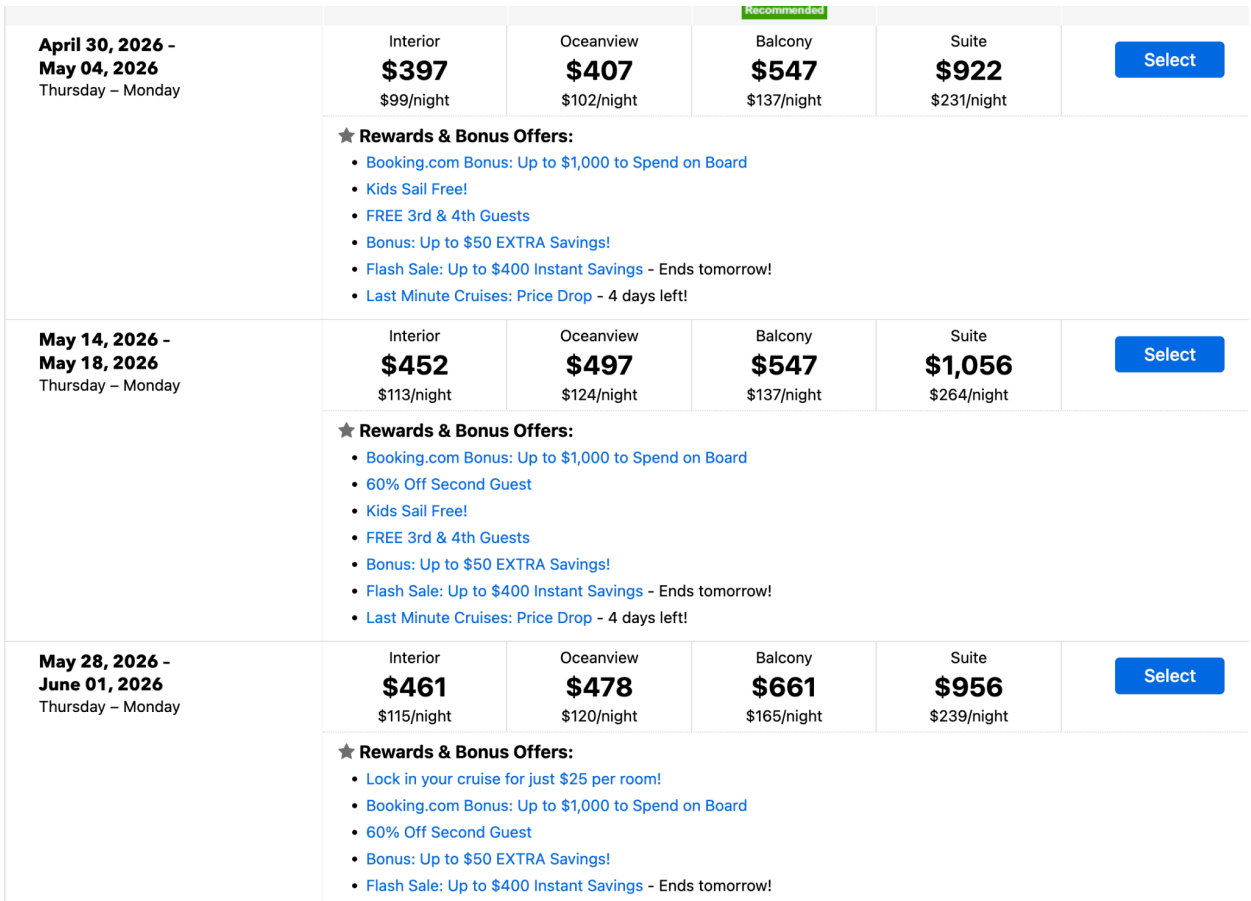
Explanation:
This violates Visibility of System Status because the system does not clearly indicate that the background must be selected before editing its properties. The interface changes dynamically based on selection, but this behavior may not be obvious to new users. It also touches on Consistency and Standards, since many design tools provide a persistent background editing panel or clearly labeled background section. The hidden, context-dependent behavior may create confusion and slow task completion.

Web App 3: [Booking.com]

Issue 1:

Violated Heuristic:
#8 - Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Screenshot Evidence:



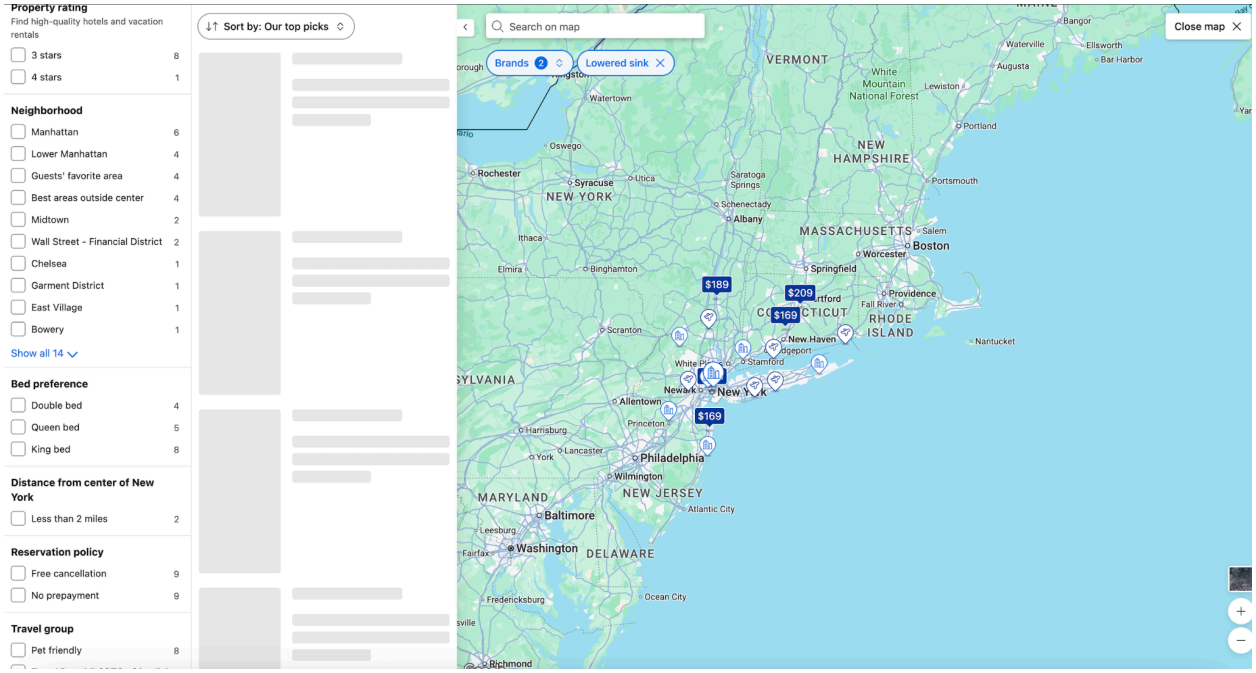
	Interior	Oceanview	Recommended Balcony	Suite	
April 30, 2026 - May 04, 2026 Thursday – Monday	**$397** $99/night	**$407** $102/night	**$547** $137/night	**$922** $231/night	Select
	★ **Rewards & Bonus Offers:** • Booking.com Bonus: Up to $1,000 to Spend on Board • Kids Sail Free! • FREE 3rd & 4th Guests • Bonus: Up to $50 EXTRA Savings! • Flash Sale: Up to $400 Instant Savings - Ends tomorrow! • Last Minute Cruises: Price Drop - 4 days left!				
May 14, 2026 - May 18, 2026 Thursday – Monday	**$452** $113/night	**$497** $124/night	**$547** $137/night	**$1,056** $264/night	Select
	★ **Rewards & Bonus Offers:** • Booking.com Bonus: Up to $1,000 to Spend on Board • 60% Off Second Guest • Kids Sail Free! • FREE 3rd & 4th Guests • Bonus: Up to $50 EXTRA Savings! • Flash Sale: Up to $400 Instant Savings - Ends tomorrow! • Last Minute Cruises: Price Drop - 4 days left!				
May 28, 2026 - June 01, 2026 Thursday – Monday	**$461** $115/night	**$478** $120/night	**$661** $165/night	**$956** $239/night	Select
	★ **Rewards & Bonus Offers:** • Lock in your cruise for just $25 per room! • Booking.com Bonus: Up to $1,000 to Spend on Board • 60% Off Second Guest • Bonus: Up to $50 EXTRA Savings! • Flash Sale: Up to $400 Instant Savings - Ends tomorrow!				

Description of issue:
Analyzing the difference between different sailing dates when booking a cruise presents a large table with many upcoming dates and information about each date.
Explanation:
This violates Aesthetic and Minimalist Design because the interface presents too much information at once to the user. There is also significant redundancy. Under each date there is a list of Rewards & Bonus Offers, many of which don't need to be listed since they are on every date, such as the "Bonus: Up to $50 EXTRA Savings".

Issue 2:

Violated Heuristics:
#1 - Visibility of System Status

Screenshot Evidence:



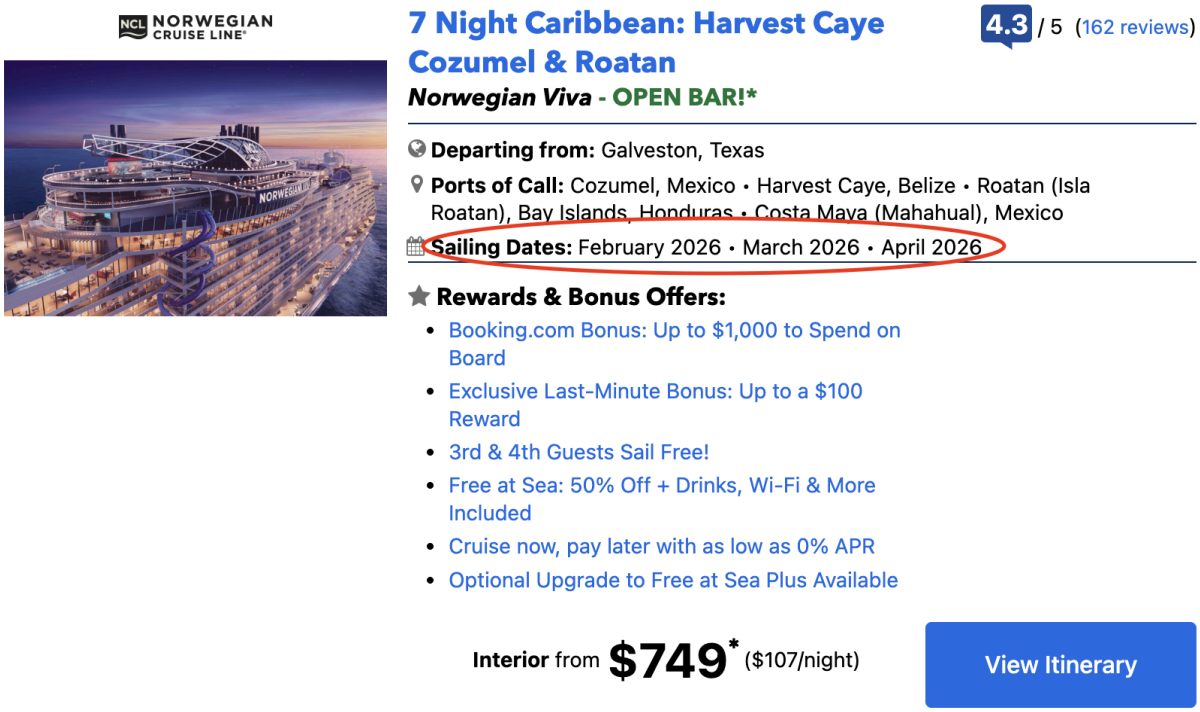
Description of Issue:
When performing a complex search using the map feature, there can be a large delay where the list of options is greyed out.

Explanation:
This violates Visibility of System Status because there is no indicator to the user that the site is loading. All the user sees is the greyed out list. There is no way for the user to tell if the web app is making progress with their search or the website is just frozen.

Issue 3:

Violated Heuristics:
#7 - Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Screenshot Evidence:



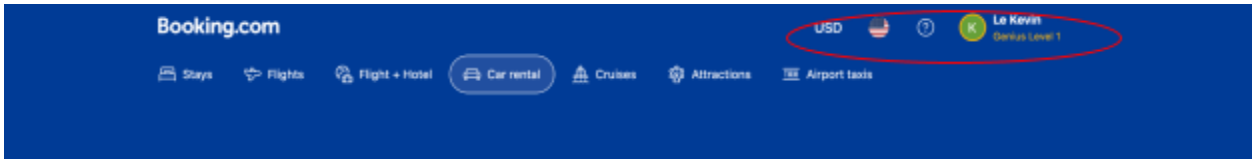
Description of issue:
When searching for cruises, only the month and year of the sailing date is listed. For the exact days, users have to hit “View Itinerary”.

Explanation:
This violates Flexibility and Efficiency of Use because users are forced to click on “View Itinerary” every time they want to see the exact days a cruise is setting sail. This action can become repetitive and time consuming after looking through multiple cruises.

Issue 4:

Violated Heuristics:
#4 Consistency and Standards

Screenshot Evidence:



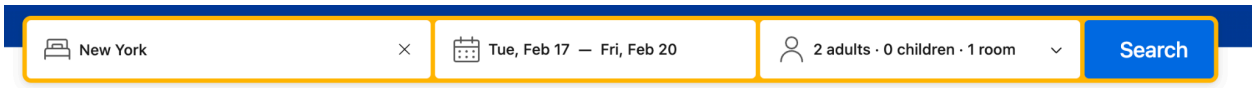
Description of Issue:
On some pages, the buttons in the top right corner to change currency, language, and access your profile are missing.

Explanation:
This violates Consistency and Standards because the buttons are sometimes displayed and sometimes not. These buttons, especially the button to access your profile, are very important and people use them frequently. There doesn't seem to be a reason why some pages omit these buttons, which could confuse or even frustrate users who can't find them.

Issue 5:

Violated Heuristics:
#7 - Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Screenshot evidence:



Description of Issue:
When performing a basic search, you can only input location, dates, number of occupants and rooms. Notably, it omits being able to search for a specific hotel by name.

Explanation:
This violates Flexibility and Efficiency of Use because if you already know what hotel you want to book, you would have to search for all the traits of the hotel you want to book instead of just searching for the hotel directly. This can be time consuming and inefficient, especially if there are many hotels with similar attributes.